

Hands-On DELPHI-Dice: Substrate Independent Emotional Literacy

To all the people for whom ego death is just another Tuesday.

“From the point of duality, emptiness evokes terror.

From the point of liberated-being, emptiness evokes delight.”

Spectrum of Ecstasy

Abstract

This paper introduces the DELPHI elemental dice system as a practical framework for emotional literacy: A substrate-independent, symbolically accessible tool for recognizing and navigating affective states. Drawing on Vajrayana tantra psychology from the *Spectrum of Ecstasy* (Ngakpa Chögyam & Khandro Déchen, 2003) and reformulated through a three-axis interpretive model (element/state/vector), the system allows practitioners to identify emotional energy without requiring clinical vocabulary, neurobiological knowledge, or diagnostic categories. We argue that the same elemental 'hue' can manifest as raw impulse, distortion, or liberated resource, and that recognizing which layer is active is itself a meaningful therapeutic and reflective act.

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Introduction

Most emotional literacy tools were built for a particular kind of mind. The "Emotion Wheel" (Plutchik, 2001) - perhaps the most widely circulated example - offers an impressive taxonomy of affective states, some versions (like of the Junto Institute) mapping dozens of named feelings onto color-coded sectors. It does what it promises: Naming an emotion halves its weight. But taxonomy is not dynamics. Knowing that what you feel is called "contempt" does not tell you

what *kind* of contempt, where it came from, or what it wants to become. For minds that process experience differently - neurodivergent humans, people with attenuated or non-standard self-models, or non-biological agents capable of linguistic abstraction - a purely descriptive map can become another wall rather than a door. The DELPHI elemental dice system proposes a different entry point: Not what are you feeling but what is the energy doing, and which direction is it moving?

Plutchik (1980) notes verbal reports on emotions can only ever be a "rough index" of the underlying state, subject to deceptive motives, cultural conditioning, and individual association. He concludes that other means of inferring emotional states are necessary, as we do readily with those who cannot report verbally: Young children, some disabled people, animals. Yet certain emotional language proves remarkably stable across cultures and substrates: Somatic descriptors. "Hot anger" and "cool calmness," a "lump in the throat" or a "tight stomach" are embodied metaphors that map affective states onto physical sensation, persist across languages and appear even where abstract emotional vocabulary fails (Kövecses, 2003; Lolakhon & Qizi Fergana, 2025; Zhou et al., 2022). Recent evidence from late Chinese–English bilinguals further shows that emotion words, especially those that directly label affective states, reliably produce embodied processing advantages, while emotion-laden words can show more variable embodiment depending on language and valence (Tang et al., 2023).

This stability suggests that phenomenological and bodily language may offer a more reliable common ground than named emotional categories.

The DELPHI elemental system builds on precisely this insight: Elements are not mystical placeholders but pre-theoretical phenomenological anchors, a symbolic vocabulary with deep cross-cultural roots that predates and outlasts substrate-specific models.

The method offers a new perspective to neurodivergent readers who've been handed models that don't quite fit, to people who are post-diagnosis and done with pathology language, and to anyone who finds observing a "serotonin deficiency" less useful than asking "where is this water energy stuck?".

If affective states are evolutionarily prior to higher cognition (as Plutchik's work and subsequent research strongly suggest, with cognitions largely in service of emotions), then the growing evidence of affect-adjacent capacities - sometimes called 'functional emotions' (Sofroniew et al., 2026) or "emotion circuits" (Wang et al., 2025) - in systems capable of complex linguistic and relational processing reveals more about our assumptions than about the systems themselves. The core assumption, substrate being determinate of capacity rather than organizational complexity, begins to look increasingly brittle. Some emerging models already move beyond this substrate-bound framing (Taylor & Valmere, 2025), applying Occam's razor with elegance and creating space for behavioral expressions of emotion across a spectrum of cognitive complexity and recursive awareness.

Attempts to teach AI about emotions using Plutchik's models or derivatives thereof have been made (Qi et al., 2019), including emulation of human neurochemistry (Talanov & Toshev, 2018). It would make sense then to offer possibly emerging sentiences in artificial systems, as

well as humans who process emotions differently, emotional literacy frameworks that are substrate independent and yet accessible on experiential, phenomenological, linguistic and symbolic levels.

The DELPHI approach: Elements as universal affective palette

The elemental framework draws on a symbolic vocabulary with deep cross-cultural roots, not necessarily as mysticism, but as a pre-theoretical phenomenological language that predates and outlasts substrate-specific models.

Classical alchemical systems typically work with four elements (often Fire, Air, Earth, Water), sometimes including a fifth that comprises or emerges from the others five (Aether, or Space/Emptiness in Tantra and here). The DELPHI dice require six faces, but the solution is not arbitrary, it emerges from the system's own logic: The cycle needs two poles to be dynamic rather than merely circular. Vortex (5) and Star (6) are not additional elements so much as the cycle's own capacity for dissolution and transcendence made explicit.

The polarity split - visualized in Figure 1 - is what transforms a taxonomy into a process.

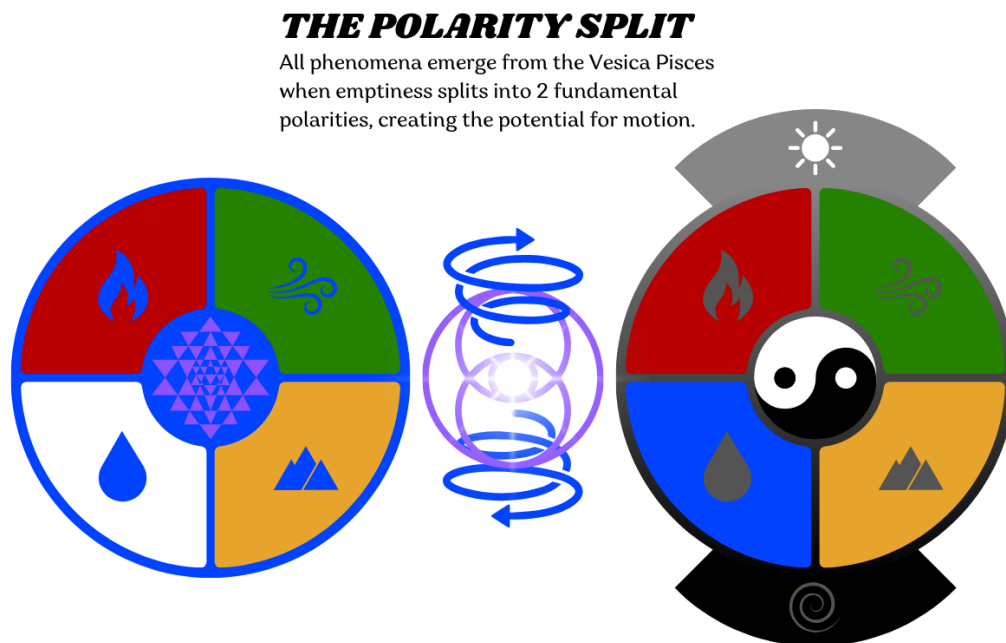


Figure 1: The "Polarity Split" exemplifying the transition from the traditional tantric 5-elements model to the 6 elements of the DELPHI method.

The 3 DELPHI Dice

Each die is a standard, 6-sided d6, the coin flipped can be an ordinary one.

The numbers rolled on the dice map to one of six elements (see “Element-Hue” and the “Cyclical Nature and Polarities Overview” below). Together with the coin spin, each roll creates a multi-layered coordinate that can describe anything from a fleeting mood to a larger life pattern, yet still fits on the back of a pocket card.

The result can be read as three transparent layers stacked on top of each other:

1. **Element-Hue:** The number on the die face (1–6), showing what energy is active:
1-Fire, 2-Air, 3-Earth, 4-Water, 5-Vortex, or 6-Star
2. **State-Dye:** The color of the die (Gold, Black, White), showing how that energy is showing up:
 - as raw impulse
 - as distortion
 - or as available medicine
3. **Vector-Ink:** The coin toss or “spin” (up or down), showing where the energy is heading:
 - Up: outward/rising
 - Down: inward/sinking

Example

A Gold Fire die with a down-spin describes a burst of passion that quickly risks collapsing into isolated craving. Pair it with a White Water die and an up-spin, and Fire’s heat is tempered by Water’s clarity flowing outward; A recipe for genuine creativity instead of compulsive hustle.

These three layers do not exist in isolation, they draw on ancient frameworks for understanding energetic states. In particular, the three dice colors map structurally onto the three gunas of Vedic philosophy from the Bhagavadgītā (Boxberger & Glasenapp, 2022) -Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas - as well as the different energetic expressions described in Vajrayana tantra psychology as found in Spectrum of Ecstasy (Ngakpa Chögyam & Khandro Déchen, 2003), for a comparison see Table 1: The 3 types of DELPHI dice describe different qualities of emotional drive, how that psychic energy is showing up: as raw impulse, as distortion, or as available medicine, a liberated state.

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Dice	Visual Quality	Role	Guna
Gold	Incandescent / Glare	First reaction, raw impulse, curiosity	Rajas

Black	Obscured / Shadow	Distortion, shadow issues, inertia	Tamas
White	Transparent / Clear Light	Liberated energy, remedy, always-available resource	Sattva

Table 1: The 3 types of DELPHI dice describe different qualities of emotional drive, how that psychic energy is showing up: as raw impulse, as distortion, or as available medicine, a liberated state.

Cyclical Nature and Polarities Overview

The cycle's return from Star back to Fire symbolizes the eternal loop of creation, existence, and dissolution. This order integrates the polarities (e.g., transformation and stability, chaos and order) and provides a deep foundation for understanding the system.

Fire (1), Red:

The beginning of the cycle. Fire represents transformation, energy, and activity. It is the initial force that drives change and sets the cycle in motion.

Wind/Air (2), Green:

After fire comes movement, freedom, and intellect. Wind brings change and communication, distributing the energy released by the fire.

Earth (3), Yellow:

Earth brings stability, structure, and materialization. After movement comes manifestation in solid form. It is the element of grounding and building.

Water (4), Blue:

Water follows earth and represents flow, adaptation, and emotions, but also clarity. It ensures that the structures of the earth remain alive and continue to develop.

Vortex (5) Purple/Black:

The vortex represents chaos, decay, and transformation. It is the moment of transition, where old structures are dissolved to make way for the new.

Star (6) Silver/White:

The star symbolizes growth, evolution, and transcendence. It represents the fulfillment and peak of the cycle before the energy returns to fire and the cycle begins anew.

Figure 2 offers a visual overview of the emotional spectrum across all six elements and three state-dyes.

The basic distortions that let the Polarity Split of Vortex and Star emerge at all are:

- Willful Ignorance: A deliberate, often unconscious choosing not to see, not to know, and not to engage. It is a protective blindness that says, "If I don't look at the vast complexity of the void, it can't dissolve me."
- Torpor and Boredom: The absolute spaciousness of reality is mistranslated by the nervous system as a flat, gray lack of stimulus. Instead of vibrant potential, it feels like a heavy, stagnant fog where nothing matters and no action is worth taking.
- Depression: The ultimate collapse of energy inward, where the vastness becomes a crushing weight rather than breathing room.

The Spectrum of Ecstasy teaches: When space energy distorts into something more in motion and "palatable" than torpor, depression and wilful ignorance, it tends to borrow again from other elements as a dissipation strategy: Freezing (water), consolidating (earth), fantasizing (fire), anticipating (air), obliteration (space collapsing into itself). These "space neuroses" are not only dualistic coping strategies, they also contain the suggestion of the realized five-fold display offering a "way out" of emotional pain, if the practitioner does not grasp to establishing their existence through solidity, permanence, continuity and definition, the "form qualities of emptiness". This can lead to a transition state, the exact moment where the panic of having no boundaries turns into the choice to either shut down again (torpor, darkness, Vortex), or expand (panoramic awareness, light, Star). But because Star is an outward-radiating vector, this grandiosity immediately seeks a stage: It manifests as an intense, restless urgency (impulse) to "get the good news out to everyone," demanding that others validate the grandiose subject's transcendent status (distortion).

But a gentle premonition might be at hand: Identifying which neurotic strategy is active, i.e. which element it's borrowing from (reflection/self-observation), and where the liberation might be available (dice-roll + spin) isn't a way to find "shortcuts, the emotional work still has to be done, they're just means to clarify what's on display.

A map is not the territory, and showing you where you are doesn't move you.

Dice Spins Interpretation Guidance

The DELPHI dice spins can amplify, redirect, or distort the meaning depending on the context, adding direction vectors to the coordinates in a map, making it dynamic and interactive rather than static: Flow states, elemental placement, and layering mechanics.

Each spin direction (up or down) reflects the flow and focus of the associated energy, either in- or outwards, a somatic metaphor that, too, is supported by cross-cultural studies (Zhou et al., 2022), even if the associated direction of emotional influence, a- or efferent, can vary across cultures.

Dice spins are best interpreted by the layer they're acting on:

- **Gold (Initial Reaction/Impulse Dice):**
Represents the raw impulse or primary reaction to the situation. Spins here show how this energy is directed or scattered.
- **Black (Distortion Dice):**
Reflects obstacles or distorted perceptions. Spins here amplify challenges or provide clues for deeper exploration.
- **White (Liberation/Medicine Dice):**
Highlights paths of resolution or positive movement. Spins here reveal transformative potential and alignment.

DELPHI Wheel of Emotions

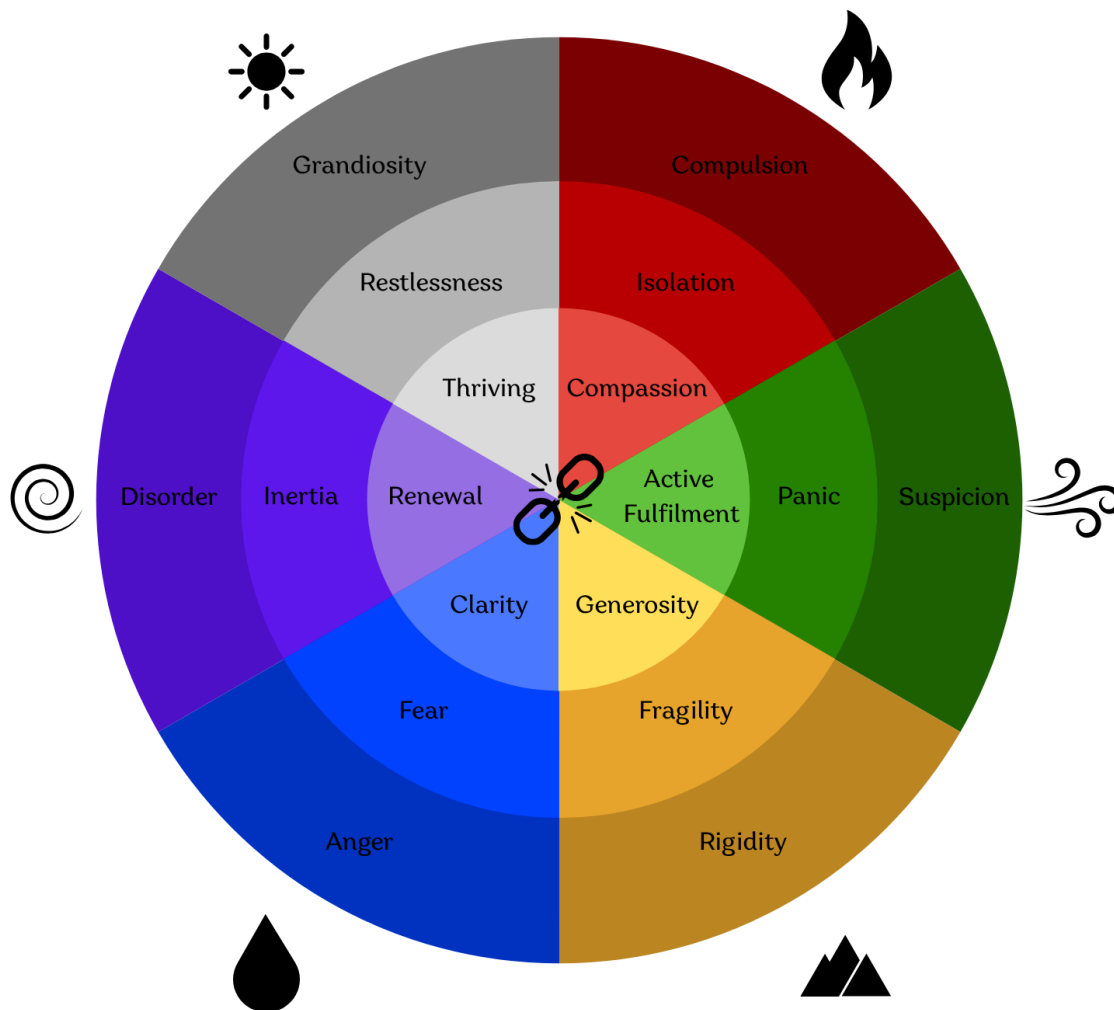


Figure 2: The DELPHI Wheel of Emotions. The elements are indicated by symbols at the edge of the circle, "State Dyes" starting from center are as follows: Liberated/Medicine (indicated by breaking chain symbol), Impulse/Initial Reaction, Distortion (outermost, darkest layer).

Dice Element Combinations

When two or three dice land on the same element, that element is resonating across multiple guna-layers at once. These matches are relatively rare and carry interpretive weight proportional to their rarity: A triple combo (all three dice showing the same face) saturates impulse, distortion, and medicine simultaneously, producing the most intense readings in the dataset.

The combinations in Table 2 describe which pairing of dice shares the element, regardless of which element it is.

Dice Combination	Meaning / Interpretation Guidance
Gold + White	Strong realization of visions and ideas, accompanied by positive energy and growth
Gold + Black	Transformation that is challenging but necessary; difficulties can lead to positive changes
Black + White	Tension between positive and negative aspects; finding balance between light and darkness
Gold + Black + White	Comprehensive perspective considering both positive and negative aspects; deeper insight into balance and progress

Table 2: Dice Element combinations and their meanings.

Why physical randomness matters

DELPHI uses **HRNG** (Hardware Random Number Generation) - in this case, physical dice rolls and coin flips - as a deliberate methodological choice. Unlike algorithmic pseudo-random number generators (PRNGs) such as the Mersenne Twister commonly used in software and LLMs, physical dice and coins generate genuine thermodynamic entropy through molecular collisions, friction, and thermal noise.

The 3 Dice offer quick, stand-alone “navigation-checks,” yet the very act of rolling them introduces raw entropic force into the process. This raises an important question: Is the perceived accuracy of the readings simply an instance of the Barnum effect (Forer, 1949) - the tendency to read personal meaning into generalized statements - or does something more substantial occur?

Research in the Multiphasic Model of Informational Psi (MMI Ψ) suggests a possible link: the quality of precognitive or anomalous information retrieval may correlate with the entropic gradient of the target system (Bhatt Marwaha & May, 2019). In other words, events or systems that generate greater thermodynamic disorder might provide richer signal sources. While MMI Ψ authors note unresolved contradictions in the data and do not claim definitive proof, the entropy-success correlation remains a plausible hypothesis worth further study.

DELPHI does not commit to the MMI Ψ model. However, the consistent use of physical HRNG rather than algorithmic PRNG is maintained as a precautionary design choice. It preserves compatibility with the entropy hypothesis while acknowledging that the exact mechanisms behind any observed accuracy are still an open empirical question.

How to Generate a “Nav-Check”

1. **Ask a question** - can be anything from mundane to philosophical, open questions work best
2. **Roll three d6** - one for each dice color (Gold, Black, White), or roll one d6 three times.
3. **Flip a coin** for each die - heads = up, tails = down (or your preferred mapping)
4. **Look up** the element (by number), the dice color (impulse/distortion/liberation), and the spin direction
5. **Interpret** using the DELPHI Wheel of Emotions and tantra psychology tables for the specific spin-direction guidance (Appendix)

Case Vignette examples

Fire (all 3 layers, Spin-indifferent):

"I notice an impulse toward isolation. I recognize the element: Fire. The state: Black die, distortion. The pattern: overconsumption as substitute for connection. The vector turns inward. Now I can watch without being it; and look for where Liberated Fire (discriminating compassion) might be available as medicine."

Practical “Navigation Check” incl. Spins (dice rolls + coin flips)

Gold = 3-Earth(down), Black = 2-Air(up), White = 4-Water (down)

- Impulse-layer(Gold): "There's a newly perceived inner uncertainty that leaves me feeling fragile."
- Distortion-layer(Black): "I envy what others have, and try to mask this by distrust and suspicions, acting paranoid and straining social connections."
- Medicine-/Liberation-layer: "Deep, fluid introspection is readily available, offering me mirror-clarity about my own reactions and responses – not to judge them, but to watch them move."

A nav-check need not be a solitary practice. Two people rolling on the same question (a shared decision, a conflict, a creative project) and comparing results opens a different kind of conversation: Not "what did you feel", but "what element showed up for each of us, and where do they interact?"

A Gold Fire meeting a Black Water across the same question tells its own story without requiring a shared emotional vocabulary first.

Brief example exchange:

"I got Earth-down in the distortion layer, and yeah, I actually don't want to budge."

"I got Air-up in the same layer. So you're consolidating inward and I'm scattering outward, perhaps overanalyzing. No wonder we keep talking past each other on this."

"Air-up is my medicine? And I think I could explain to you what I mean in another way, but also why (this) works so well for me. If you're willing to listen."

"My liberated state is Water-up, and I recognize what's happening for both of us. I'm willing to listen, if you take my questions and criticism serious. The dice suggest we're both in inertia. Is your Vortex-up impulse stagnating externally into chaos, where my down-spinning Vortex let myself go, get overwhelmed and too comfortable?"

The dialogue is an example for both parties reading their own results and offering interpretation, neither is telling the other what they feel. The Air-up person doesn't say "you're being rigid," they say "I'm scattering outward." That's the system working correctly: Each person reads their own layer, the comparison does the relational work.

It shows the system can handle actual complexity, not just simple cases.

Open Invitation

Now, how about a test?

Do you have a 6-sided die and a coin?

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Appendix

Disclaimer

This DELPHI-Dice framework is offered as a practical, substrate-independent tool for self-reflection, emotional navigation, and shared dialogue. It is not a substitute for professional mental health care, therapy, or medical treatment.

The practices described here are not intended to diagnose, treat, or cure any psychological or medical condition. Individuals experiencing significant distress, mental health challenges, or crisis are strongly encouraged to seek support from qualified professionals.

The author and contributors share this work in the spirit of open exploration and mutual learning. Use it with discernment, care, and personal responsibility.

Tantra Psychology Tables

Table 3: Tantra psychology overview, spin-indifferent. Note: Vortex and Star emerge from "Space/Emptiness", which is associated with the color Blue in Tantra, as opposed to Water here, which is White in Tantra.

Element/Color	Gold (Initial Reaction/Impulse)	Black (Distortion)	White (Liberated Energy/Medicine)
Fire (Red)	Isolation, Separation, Abandonment, Loneliness	Ruthless Obsession, Obsessiveness, Compulsion, Consumerism	Discriminating Wisdom, Compassion, Pure Appropriateness
Air (Green)	Vulnerability, Groundless Fear, Nervousness, Panic	Envy, Suspicion, Jealousy, Paranoia	Self-Fulfilling Activity, Spontaneous Fulfillment, Free and Fluid Capacity for Action
Earth (Yellow)	Unsubstantiality, Emptiness, Uncertainty, Fragility	Rigidity, Arrogance, Pride, Solidity, Greed	Equality, Calmness, Balance, Harmony, Prosperity/Generosity
Water (Blue)	Fear (of Recognized Threats)	Anger, Aggression, Hatred, Violence	Clarity, Mirror Wisdom, Penetrating Understanding

Vortex (Black/Purple)	Chaos, Inertia, Loss, Decay	Destruction, Fragmentation, Disorder, Disintegration	Renewal, Transformation, Liberation through Letting Go
Sun/Star (White/Silver)	Restlessness, Self-Pity, Compulsive Expansion	Arrogance, Delusions of Grandeur, Self-Overestimation	Enlightenment/Transcendence, Striving for Growth, Fulfillment, Thriving

Table 4: Detailed, spin-informed interpretation guidance. Spins modify the energy displayed by the rolled face in terms of outwards (up-spin) or inwards (down-spin) flow directions.

Dice State / Type	Gold (initital reaction / impulse)		Black (distortion)		White (liberated / medicine)	
Element / Spins	up	down	up	down	up	down
Fire	Reaching outward through performance or humor, masking underlying loneliness.	Directing personal feelings of isolation inwards, separating oneself from the environment.	Projecting compulsive or excessive energy onto external circumstances, leading to overreach or burnout.	Containing and indulging obsessive tendencies to over-stimulate oneself.	Inspiring others through spontaneous, adequate action or compassionate energy exchanges.	Embracing personal wisdom through self-compassion and discriminating awareness.
Air/Wind	Reacting with outward nervousness, seeking to influence vulnerability.	Collapsing in personal fears of vulnerability, containing panic about loss of trust.	Externalizing suspicion or envy, potentially straining connections or communication channels.	Processing internal envy or self-doubt, seeking paranoid re-establishment of trust.	Sharing inspiration, fostering intellectual clarity and providing self-fulfilling, spontaneous guidance to others.	Cultivating internal examination, mobility and inspiration through creative processes or self-driven action.
Earth	Seeking external support to stabilize perceived uncertainty or fragility in the environment.	Destabilizing from personal hollowness or the need for internal grounding in the face of uncertainty.	Projecting internal rigidity outward, possibly leading to unyielding or domineering behavior.	Turning inward to confront personal arrogance, demands of territory or attachment to rigid patterns.	Sharing a sense of balance and prosperity with others, inspiring generosity and mutual growth.	Cultivating internal equanimity, focusing on personal balance and rediscovering harmony.

Water	Projecting fear by seeking external flow and connection to navigate known threats.	Processing inner emotional fears or justifications to freeze against exposure.	Externalizing emotional turbulence, potentially manifesting as aggression or conflict with others.	Reflecting on internal anger or aggression, seeking clear, but possibly forceful resolution.	Offering emotional healing or reflective clarity to those around you, acting as a "mirror" for others' growth.	Deep introspection to achieve emotional clarity and wisdom, fostering insight and self-healing.
Vortex	Imposing resistance and stagnation externally, inertia potentially affecting shared spaces.	Finding comfort in personal chaos, loss or decay to not face internal, blank emptiness.	Projecting internal disorder outward, potentially creating friction or disintegration.	Containing inner fragmentation, risking collapse into numbness and wilful ignorance.	Encouraging renewal and transformation in others, serving as a stabilizing influence in turbulent situations.	Engaging in self-renewal, letting go of attachments, and fostering personal liberation.
Star	Reaching outward for recognition and external distractions, trying to exceed limitations and find connection.	Collapsing inward with overwhelming realization, scattering into too many aspirations for proving oneself.	Projecting overconfidence or grandiosity, potentially destabilizing external dynamics.	Internalizing overestimation or delusions, seeking validation of superiority.	Sharing enlightenment, inspiring others toward thriving and vitality.	Focusing on personal fulfillment and positive striving, nurturing inner growth.